FM Handover Checklist: New Building Takeover

A 60-point checklist for taking a new or refurbished building from the project team into operations

A handover is the moment the project team stops owning the building and the operations team starts. Most of the cost of a bad handover is paid in year one: undocumented plant, missing warranties, alarms nobody has tested and a maintenance contract priced against a building that does not match the drawings. This checklist is the one Chapter members use to refuse a handover until the evidence is in the room.

1. Documents the operations team must hold on day one

- As-built drawings (architectural, structural, MEP, fire, BMS) in editable and PDF form, signed by the contractor
- Operation and maintenance manuals for every item of plant, indexed by asset tag
- Warranty register with start dates, durations, exclusions and the contractor contact for each item
- Statutory approvals: fire NOC, occupancy certificate, lift licences, DG and boiler certificates, pollution consent
- Test and commissioning certificates with the witnessed readings, not just the cover sheet
- Spares and special tools schedule, with quantities received
- Training attendance sheets for each system (security, BMS, HVAC, fire, lifts, DG)

2. Physical walk-down

1. Walk every floor with the main contractor and note defects on a snag list with photographs and a location code.
2. Test every fire alarm device, sprinkler flow switch and emergency light; record the panel response time.
3. Run each lift through full-load, fireman and power-failure modes with the lift contractor present.
4. Check every plant room for access, lighting, drainage, labelling and a clear maintenance envelope.
5. Confirm every meter, sub-meter and BMS point reads sensibly against a handheld instrument.
6. Inspect roof, terraces, basement and service shafts for water ingress, ponding and unprotected openings.

3. Systems and data

System	Evidence required	Owner	Accepted
Fire detection and alarm	Zone chart, cause-and-effect test, panel log	Fire engineer	[ ]
Sprinkler and hydrants	Hydraulic test, pump curve, flow test	MEP lead	[ ]
HVAC and chilled water	Balancing report, setpoint schedule, trend logs	MEP lead	[ ]
Electrical and DG	Thermography, earth-pit readings, DG load test	Electrical lead	[ ]
BMS and metering	Point list, graphics, alarm limits, trend export	BMS engineer	[ ]
Lifts and escalators	Licence, load test, emergency phone test	Lift contractor	[ ]

4. Contracts and people

- Every service contract mapped to the assets and areas it covers; no gaps and no double cover
- Response and resolution times agreed, with an escalation matrix that names a person for every level
- Helpdesk, CMMS and permit-to-work configured before the first tenant or employee arrives
- A named defects-liability owner who chases the contractor until the last snag is closed
- Emergency contact tree printed, tested by phone and held at the security desk

5. Sign-off rules

Do not sign a handover certificate with open category-A items (anything that affects life safety, statutory compliance or the ability to occupy). Category-B items go on the defects register with a dated owner. Keep the retention money until the warranty register, the as-built set and the training records are complete.